

court, on the basis of media reports, asked the Government suo moto to "disband the police force as it had totally failed to control law and order in the state". It also sought the case figures along with the steps being taken.

However, finding that the police were unable to present a clear picture, a division bench of the high court comprising Chief Justice J.N. Bhatt and Justice Mihir Kumar Jha asked the district judges to furnish a monthly status report on the number of kidnapping cases registered and disposed of. Recently, the police administration submitted an 'updated

few cases are sensationalised by the media, people get panicky," he asserts. But the Government's stand is being contradicted by reports that are pouring in from district courts. According to M.P. Gupta, general secretary of the Council for Protection of Public Rights and Welfare and amicus curiae appointed by the high court, the police claim before the court that between May 15 and July 27, 2007 they recovered 54 children is nothing but a lie as during that period 51 children were abducted. "So the figure remains the same." He says between July 2006 and June 2007, a total of

PRAYER ON THEIR LIPS: Akash's classmates perform havan



status report' on the action taken on the cases of abduction of children. While it indicates a decline in the number of kidnappings since November 2005, when the new Government took over the reins, the report makes a sensational reading: between 2001 and June 23, 2007, a total of 2,068 children were kidnapped in Bihar. While the police succeeded in recovering 1,690 children from the clutches of kidnappers, 304 are still not traceable. The report also highlights the macabre fact that over 74 victims were slain by kidnappers. The state capital tops with 36 killings, followed by Bhagalpur (16), Muzaffarpur (13) and Darbhanga (nine).

The high court has granted the administration time—to complete its homework—till October 4. Amanullah claims change is visible as markets, malls and cinema houses, which used to wear a deserted look after sundown earlier, are now open till late night and people move around fearlessly. "As a

4,849 people were kidnapped. Of these, at least 2,217 were kidnapped only in the first half of this year. Besides, in all, 14,276 abduction cases are pending in various courts.

While the figures furnished by the police and sent by the district judges don't match, an independent study conducted by the Crime Branch of the state police makes an interesting point. According to it, more young girls and boys are kidnapped for marriage than for ransom. Such marriages, common in some north Bihar districts including Muzaffarpur, Begusarai and Samastipur, are called *pakadua shaadi*. Out of the total cases of kidnapping recorded between January and June this year, says the Crime Branch analysis, 419 were for marriage and only 48 were executed for ransom. Besides, a majority of those abducted were girls which indicated that the fair sex was targeted by the boys' sides. Also, 201 kidnappings

for which FIRs were lodged, were found to be cases of elopement.

It is the ransom cases that actually create fear though. A number of mafias, who have entered politics, control a well-knit 'syndicate' to carry out abductions. Of all the crimes, kidnapping-for-ransom is the safest as the victim's family does not normally involve the police.

The gangs earlier used to target only wealthy farmers but then found that kidnapping and extortion of professionals like doctors, engineers as well as contractors, businessmen and the children of the wealthy was far more lucrative.

However, as Amanullah claims, due to police crackdown and speedy trial of cases, the number of such incidents has declined. And now with the high court cracking the whip to force the administration to become responsive, the situation might improve further. This is the kind of hope on which Bihar is living now.

COURT SPEAK

■ The police version, that in 45 days they recovered 54 children, holds no water. During the same period, 51 children were abducted.

■ Of the 4,849 cases registered between July 2006 and June 2007, at least 2,217 were kidnapped in the first half of this year alone.

■ In all, 14,276 abduction cases are pending in various courts.

CRIME BRANCH STUDY

■ At least 419 kidnappings between January and June this year were for reasons of marriage while only 48 were for ransom.

■ Majority among the kidnapped for marriage were girls.

■ 201 incidents of kidnapping involving boys and girls were found to be cases of elopement.

■ The practice of kidnapping for forcible marriage is common in some of the northern districts.